IN SEARCH OF A PRE

SOME NAMES DOING THE ROUNDS, THOUGH THE FINAL CHOICE COU

the choice of president for the party.

The organisational elections that began in December 2024 were originally meant to be routine, but have now acquired a new salience. The RSS is certain that the president this time must be one of their own. Not just a charismatic campaigner, but a disciplined organiser, a Hindutva loyalist with deep roots in the Parivar ecosystem. An insider, not an import. Someone who can seamlessly lead the party into a post-Narendra Modi era. So, who fits the bill?

THE PROBABLES

Dharmendra Pradhan, the current Union minister of education and earlier in charge of petroleum, is one contender. His rise from the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) stable, his ability to push the BJP's OBC outreach without alienating the core, and his rapport with Dattatreya Hosabale, the current #2 in the RSS, make him the most ideologically aligned and politically agile candidate. He has worked closely with past party presidents: Rajnath Singh, Nitin Gadkari and Amit Shah. At 56, he offers a generational shift without provoking rebellion.

Then, there's Bhupender Yadav, the Union environment minister and a seasoned organisation man. A lawyer by training, he rose through the ranks of the Sangh's Adhivakta Parishad and earned his stripes as a shrewd poll manager, especially in Rajasthan and Maharashtra. In 2019, when Nadda was picked as party president, Yadav was in serious contention and was even coordinating calls to key partymen before the announcement.

Manohar Lal Khattar, former Haryana chief minister and current Union housing minister, is another possibility. A committed pracharak before entering electoral politics, Khattar ticks many ideological boxes. He enjoys proximity to Prime Minister Modi and holds favour among Sangh pracharaks like Arun Kumar. However, Khattar's tenure as CM ended amid murmurs about his inaccessibility and a top-down style that alienated both party workers and allies. His low-key presence in the cabinet has done little to reverse that perception.

There could be dark horses too. Shivraj Singh Chouhan, former Madhya Pradesh CM and now Union agriculture minister, is one of them. Still popular within the BJP base, Shivraj has quietly built goodwill within both the cabinet and Sangh ranks. His backers include veteran pracharak Suresh Soni—who also supports Pradhan—and he is seen as a man who can rally disparate factions. His governance record and mass connect remain his trump cards. But his age could count against him: Shivraj is 66. In a party increasingly nudged toward generational change, he may be seen as a transitional figure—good for now but not in a post-Modi scenario.

Then, there is the wild card: Sanjay Joshi. A Nagpur boy, former general secretary (organisation) and an ideological purist. Joshi's relations in Nagpur remain strong; he shares old ties with Mohan Bhagwat, Manmohan

THE FRONTRUNNERS



Dharmendra Pradhan, 56

Union Minister of Education

His ABVP background, ability to push BJP's OBC outreach and rapport with Sarkaryavah Dattatreya Hosabale make him the most ideologically aligned and politically agile candidate

Bhupender Yadav, 56

Union Minister of Environment

Organisation man, lawyer by training who rose through the ranks of the Sangh's Adhivakta Parishad. Played a crucial role in both the Rajasthan and Maharashtra assembly elections. Was a contender in 2019 too





Manohar Lal Khattar, 71

Union Minister of Housing and Urban Affairs

A lifelong pracharak, the former chief minister of Haryana ticks many an ideological box. He is close to Prime Minister Narendra Modi as well as Sangh pracharaks like Arun Kumar Khanna. Age, though, may not be on his side

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